

IN HIS LIKENESS Banner in Raebareli depicting Akhilesh Yadav as Krishna and a local leader as Sudama

▶ UTTAR PRADESH

EDGE OF THE SEAT SUSPENSE

The SP and Congress are in the hard bargaining phase. The tension is showing at times, then melting, as the 'Do Ladke' head into another poll test

By **Avaneesh Mishra**

IN LATE OCTOBER, THE GOSSIP IN LUCKNOW was all about a new set of posters. Featuring Rahul, Priyanka and Sonia Gandhi, they carried the slogan: '200 seats—Our Right, UP trusts Rahul Gandhi'. It's still not too clear who put those up. Was the Congress really upping the ante in seat-sharing negotiations with the Samajwadi Party (SP)? Or was a saboteur using a known point of discord to drive a wedge between friends?

A month before that, it was in Raebareli that posters had turned conversations in unforeseen directions. Those portrayed Akhilesh Yadav decked up as Lord Krishna, with a local SP leader featuring himself as Sudama. His boss had pointedly chosen to launch the 'PDA rath yatra' from Rahul's Lok Sabha constituency, almost as if to imply nothing in a democracy was exactly private property. And no better way to banish the idea of trespass than a local face welcoming him to 'Sudama's land'.

So what's going on? Friendly fire between doubles partners?

When asked, Akhilesh smiles indulgently and waves away any suggestion of serious disharmony. In fact, he saved the Congress some blushes by calling the Lucknow posters fake and suggesting the BJP's counter-intelligence wing was up to its black ops! As for the Krishna cosplay, it involved a bit of colourful folk etymology: it's actually a 14th century chieftain, 'Sudaman', who gives a Raebareli locality that name.

But Congress leaders did not miss the message. Ajay Rai, who has since been replaced as state chief in a surprise reshuffle, had let the barbs fly. Congress leaders, too, could freely travel to SP strongholds such as Etawah, Kannauj and Mainpuri, he said. SP veteran Shivpal Yadav said sure, you are welcome anytime, just don't expect a gift of votes. Again, Akhilesh had made light of the repartee, calling it "tricks of the trade" that wouldn't rupture alliance unity.

In fact, thoughts of fraternity may